banished on the Haj.

Shortly afterwards, however – and to the great relief, no doubt, of his exhausted nobility – Chenghis Khan of Gujarat died, and Akbar found a new focus for his energies.

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Chenghis Khan was not the king of Gujarat. Gujarat had not had a king possessed of any extensive command or worth for some decades. Its last notable ruler, Sultan Bahadur of the Muzaffarid dynasty, died during Humayun's first innings in Hindustan – drowned, possibly killed, while escaping a Portuguese ship, having signed the Treaty of Bassein with the European merchant-conquerors some years previously, by which they gained, amongst other things, an archipelago of seven islands on India's western coast.

Sultan Bahadur's successors have no such historical relevance except in that they were dominated, increasingly, by their nobility. Thus, before Akbar turned his eyes upon it, Gujarat was parcelled out amongst many chiefs, ruling its various cities and ports in watchful alliance.

Chenghis Khan held some of its richest cities, including Surat and its busy port; Sher Khan Fuladi held Patan, where Bairam Khan had been killed; Sayyid Hamid and Amin Khan Ghori held other regions of north-western Gujarat; and one Itimad Khan, most clever of all, held Ahmedabad, Cambay and a boy named Nannu, scion of the Muzaffarid dynasty. Besides these rulers, some of Akbar's disaffected nobility, too, had ambitions in Gujarat. Most prominently, the Mirzas had allied with Chenghis Khan against Itimad Khan of Ahmedabad, and briefly ruled Broach as reward.

Chenghis Khan's demise upset whatever understanding these various ambitious men had had between themselves. Almost immediately, it seems, Sher Khan Fuladi lured young Nannu to himself in Patan, and attacked Itimad Khan in Ahmedabad. The Mirzas, whose relations with Chenghis Khan had soured, forcing them to return to Akbar's realm, if not to his fold, now hurried back to grab what they could in Gujarat – and managed to take Champaner and Surat. Meanwhile, for reasons best known to him, Itimad Khan approached the Mirzas – who had so recently fought against him – for an alliance against Sher Khan Fuladi. At this, writes Abul Fazl, 'the market for contention became brisk' – not least because the slippery Mirzas chose